

FREE AT LAST

India wins a momentous diplomatic battle to end the nuclear apartheid against it. It can now trade in sensitive technology, its global stature is enhanced and friendship with the US sealed.

■ By Raj Chengappa
with Saurabh Shukla

In his hotel room in Vienna, Foreign Secretary Shivshankar Menon sat tensed waiting for the outcome of the plenary session of the 45-member Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) on September 6. He was conscious of the irony. The NSG was formed in 1974 as part of an angry reaction to India's first nuclear test. Now it was meeting to make a special amendment in its rules that would allow its members to trade with the very country that the group had been set up to isolate. Around noon, Menon got three simultaneous SMSs from negotiators inside, simply stating: "We have done it". He savoured the moment and his first reaction was, as he later told INDIA TODAY, "We had finally ended the nuclear apartheid that we had faced for 34 years. We were free at last."

Menon was soon on the line to Delhi along with Shyam Saran, a former foreign secretary and the prime minister's special envoy. They first spoke to the prime minister who had been anxiously watching television flashes of news coming from the NSG deliberations in Vienna at his residence at Race Course Road. Manmohan Singh congratulated the team describing it as a momentous day. Then the two informed External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee who was equally jubilant. Manmohan was soon on the line complimenting Mukherjee who replied, "It is really your brainchild." Later that day, Manmohan spoke to US President George W. Bush and thanked him for his "strong leadership" that helped see the deal through.

In doing so, India and the US had pulled off what was considered impossible. Signed in July 2005, the Indo-US civilian nuclear agreement was the



INDIA'S A TEAM & how they did it



AP PHOTO MANISH SWARUP

MANMOHAN SINGH: It was the prime minister's bold gamble and strong resolve in the face of daunting odds that was the key.



P. MUKHERJEE: He understood that it needed both a political and diplomatic effort to realise it.



M.K. NARAYANAN: The NSA worked out what the redlines were for India's strategic programme.



SHYAM SARAN: Was key in persuading a host of fence sitters to back India at the NSG.



S. MENON: The sharp shooter, his enormous diplomatic skills made the difference.



ANIL KAKODKAR: His no-nonsense approach and knowledge strengthened negotiators' stand.



RONEN SEN: The envoy ensured that sustained US pressure continued for the waiver.

boldest foreign policy gamble to radically transform relations between them. To do so, the US decided to remove the single biggest irritant: India's nuclear ambition. The US had led the world in building a technology denial regime to isolate India. Now in order to dismantle the fortress, the US would first have to amend its own laws that prohibited trade with countries that hadn't signed the NPT. The enabling legislation for such a waiver became

the controversial Hyde Act. It was followed by the bilateral 123 Agreement that laid down the framework for civilian nuclear trade between the two countries. But the deal floundered after the Left parties, then a constituent of the ruling UPA, raised serious objections and walked out of the coalition. That forced a trust vote in August which the Manmohan Government narrowly won.

Meanwhile, as part of the deal